During his visit to New Delhi in January 1956, Chou En-lai made a pitch for a one-on-one swap between Aksai Chin and NEFA. In talks with Nehru, he said that China had accepted the boundary between Tibet and Burma as the 1914 Simla Agreement defined it. He added that the Chinese government was proposing to recognize the McMahon Line and would be consulting the Tibetans shortly. Later in the day, Chou En-lai suggested to Durga Das, the editor of the *Hindustan Times*, a quid pro quo, once again linking NEFA to Aksai Chin, something that was not acceptable to the Indian prime minister.

UPPING THE ANTE

Nehru had earlier dismissed reports about the construction of a road in Aksai Chin. National Highway G219, however, became a reality when its completion was announced in Chinese newspapers in October 1957. It was later said that part of the reason that India was not aware of the road is that Indian border patrols had never successfully entered the area at that time.

The news of the road's completion, when it was transmitted to New Delhi through its embassy in Peking, stunned Nehru. However, it is not true that the Indians had no inkling of this. On 17 November 1950, a report appeared in *The Statesman* to the effect that the Indian government had been informed of the movement of Chinese troops from Sinkiang to Western Tibet by its agent at Gartok. Whether the Indian government took any action on this report is not known. But the Chinese continued to use this route to supply their troops in Western Tibet. In 1952, Director, IB, B. N. Mullik, had reported that work on a highway linking Tibet with Sinkiang, which cut across the Aksai Chin, had started. In 1955, the Indian military attaché reported to Army HQ that the road was indeed being constructed and the road alignment had been completed. A year later, the same officer reported that work on the strategic highway had commenced and would be completed within two years. This time the letter was copied to the Ministry of External Affairs as well.

Because of the onset of winter, there was no immediate reaction from India to the announcement. Strangely, no one thought of using IAF Canberra to do an aerial reconnaissance of the area. In July 1958, a Chinese patrol had, for the first time, moved across the established line dividing Tibet and Ladakh and occupied the Khurnak Fort which lay well to the west of the boundary line. With the road completed, the Chinese were no longer